

THE WAY

Provisional Theological Baseline

What the Assembly may presently teach - and what it must still call open

A boundary document, not a creed of compulsory assent

Version 0.8 | September 19, 2026

UNDECIDED

Research draft - not a closed canon or creed

Purpose

This baseline prevents two opposite errors: pretending the Way has no theological content at all, and pretending unresolved research has already become doctrine. It states the highest-confidence institutional teaching presently supported by v0.8.

1. Status grammar

State	Institutional meaning
Established	Strong evidence and broad responsible agreement for the defined claim; revision remains possible.
Well-Supported	Substantial evidence favors the claim, but meaningful uncertainty or dispute remains.
Provisional	Plausible working conclusion useful for practice or further inquiry, explicitly subject to revision.
Permitted Interpretation	A coherent interpretation Companions may hold, but the Assembly does not teach it as the best-established conclusion.
Open Question	Available evidence does not justify an Assembly conclusion.
Rejected as Harmful or Unsupported	Either evidentially untenable for the defined claim, or institutionally impermissible because the proposed use violates rights/safeguards. The reason must be stated.

2. Current baseline

ID	Domain	Status	Current statement
BT-001	Ultimate reality	Established	Religious traditions make materially different claims about God/ultimate reality; the Way must not erase those differences.
BT-002	God-language	Provisional	Companions and Houses may pray using ordinary God-language; the Assembly has not fixed a comprehensive metaphysical doctrine of God.
BT-003	Revelation method	Established	A revelation claim is testimony requiring evaluation; intensity, office, charisma, or sincerity does not itself establish divine origin.
BT-004	Revelation authority	Established	No claimed revelation overrides consent, safeguarding, civil law, financial controls, or governing documents.

ID	Domain	Status	Current statement
BT-005	Jesus - history	Established	Jesus was a first-century Jewish figure whose movement continued after his crucifixion under Pontius Pilate.
BT-006	Jesus - identity	Open Question	Incarnation, ontological divine sonship, Trinity, atonement mechanisms, and resurrection metaphysics are not yet Assembly doctrine.
BT-007	Muhammad - history	Established	Muhammad was a seventh-century Arabian religious/political leader; the Qur'an is the earliest principal textual witness to his proclamation.
BT-008	Muhammad - revelation/finality	Open Question	Divine authorship of the Qur'an and finality of prophethood are studied seriously but are not yet Assembly doctrine.
BT-009	Buddha - history/teaching	Established	A historical Gautama stands behind Buddhism; early teaching centers liberation from suffering through disciplined ethical and contemplative practice.
BT-010	Buddha - metaphysics	Open Question	Rebirth, karma across lives, nirvana's metaphysical nature, and the ultimate implications of non-self remain open.
BT-011	Scripture	Established	The Assembly presently maintains a Library of Witnesses rather than a closed canon.
BT-012	Library inclusion	Established	Inclusion signifies relevance for study, not inspiration, infallibility, or total endorsement.
BT-013	Human dignity	Established	Human dignity and conscience do not depend on membership, office, purity status, wealth, sex, belief certainty, or loyalty to the institution.
BT-014	Human fallibility	Established	All people, including founders and ministers, are vulnerable to bias, self-deception, harmful desire, and social influence; governance must assume fallibility.

ID	Domain	Status	Current statement
BT-015	Human transformation	Well-Supported	Attention, honesty, compassion, restraint, study, service, relationship, and repair are defensible formation goals across multiple anthropological models.
BT-016	Soul / afterlife	Open Question	Immortal soul, resurrection, rebirth, postmortem consciousness, and related mechanisms remain unresolved.

3. Things the Assembly must not presently claim as settled

- That all religions secretly teach the same metaphysics.
- That one living leader has uniquely infallible access to God or ultimate reality.
- That a private revelation binds another adult without ordinary consent and governance.
- That Jesus' divinity, Trinity, atonement mechanism, or resurrection metaphysics have already been established as Way doctrine.
- That Muhammad's final prophethood or the Qur'an's divine authorship has already been established as Way doctrine.
- That Buddhist rebirth, the metaphysical nature of nirvana, or a final interpretation of non-self has already been established as Way doctrine.
- That the Library of Witnesses is itself a canon.
- That immortal soul, reincarnation, resurrection, or annihilation after death has been established.

4. Things Houses of Prayer may responsibly teach now

- The difference between Encounter, Testimony, Interpretation, Teaching, and Doctrine.
- How major source traditions understand themselves, with their disagreements preserved.
- That historical method can assess sources and events but cannot simply certify supernatural causation.
- That human beings are fallible, vulnerable to self-deception and harmful desire, and capable of compassion, repair, learning, and transformation.
- That prayer, study, ethical practice, service, attention, and companionship can be practiced without requiring false certainty about unresolved metaphysics.
- That conscience, safe exit, safeguarding, and ordinary civil rights are never suspended by theological claims.

5. Teaching-label protocol

Every curriculum, sermon, publication, or formation module making a substantial disputed theological claim should identify the relevant status when misunderstanding is reasonably likely: Established, Well-Supported, Provisional, Permitted Interpretation, Open Question, or Rejected as Harmful/Unsupported.

6. Review and amendment

This baseline should receive a formal research review at least annually during the founding period and whenever a major dossier materially changes. Lowering an Open Question to a dogmatic certainty requires the same evidentiary discipline as any other claim and may not be achieved through repetition, founder preference, donor pressure, or liturgical habit.

7. Next research wave

- TQ-008 - sin / ignorance / suffering / evil
- TQ-009 - salvation / liberation / awakening
- TQ-010 - death / resurrection / afterlife / rebirth
- TQ-011 - sexuality / marriage / family
- TQ-012 - violence / nonviolence / just protection
- TQ-013 - sacraments / rites / sacred mediation
- TQ-014 - ordination / clergy ontology
- TQ-015 - holy days / sacred calendar
- TQ-016 - interreligious identity